

Libya



An Arab country that was a pariah state for decades until trade sanctions were lifted in 2004.

c.700 BCE Phoenician traders establish settlements in Tripolitania, in the northwest, while Cyrenaica in the northeast is settled by Greeks.

1st century BCE Coastal region becomes part of Roman Empire. Roman rule is subsequently extended inland to Fezzan.

647 CE Arab invasions end Byzantine rule.

1158 Almohads from Morocco establish control over Tripolitania and rule for the next 350 years. Cyrenaica comes under Egyptian control.

1510 Tripoli is captured by Spanish King Ferdinand.

1551 Sinan Pasha recaptures Tripoli, establishing Ottoman rule. Turkish pashas rule from Tripoli.

1711 Ahmad Karamanli kills Ottoman pasha. Governorship of Tripoli becomes hereditary office of the Karamanli family.

1835 Ottoman forces are dispatched to Tripoli as a result of a disputed succession within the Karamanli family. Karamanli leader is deposed. Within a few years a militant Muslim sect known as the Sanusi or Senussi is founded.

1911 Italy attacks Tripoli and Libyan ports. In 1912 the Ottoman Empire yields control of Libya to Italy in the Treaty of Ouchy.

1914 Italian military supremacy is established in most of the country, but there are continuing attacks from rebel Senussi in the south.

1932 The Italians reestablish control after the defeat of Senussi forces seeking self-government. Italian colonists begin to arrive.

1943 British forces finally capture Tripoli and set up a military administration.

1951 The United Republic of Libya (comprising Tripolitania, Cyrenaica, and Fezzan) is proclaimed with Mohammed Sayed Idris el-Senussi, the Emir of Cyrenaica, as king.

1969 King Idris is deposed in a bloodless coup by the Revolutionary Command Council led by Colonel Muammar Gaddafi. Tripoli Charter sets up an alliance with Egypt and Sudan.

1970 UK and US military ordered out. Property of Italians and Jews is confiscated. Western oil company assets are nationalized.

1973 Libya forms abortive union with Egypt. Gaddafi launches the "Cultural Revolution"; occupies Aozou Strip in Chad.

1974 Libya forms union with Tunisia.

1977 Official name changed to the Great Socialist People's Libyan Arab Jamahiriyah.

1984 Gunman at Libyan embassy in London kills a policewoman; UK severs diplomatic relations with Libya (until 1999). Libya signs Oudja Accord with Morocco for an Arab African Federation.

1985 Libya expels 30,000 foreign workers; Tunisia cuts diplomatic links.

1986 US aircraft bomb Libya, killing 101 people and destroying Gaddafi's residence in punishment for Libya's alleged support of international terrorism.

1988 Pan-Am airliner explodes over Lockerbie, Scotland. Libyan involvement is alleged.

1989 Arab Maghreb Union established with Algeria, Morocco, Mauritania, and Tunisia. Libya and Chad ceasefire in Aozou Strip.

1992–93 UN sanctions imposed as Libya fails to hand over Lockerbie suspects.

1994 Religious leaders obtain the right to issue religious fatwas for first time

since 1969. The contested Aozou strip is finally returned to Chad.

1996 US imposes penalties on companies investing in Libya's energy sector.

1999 Lockerbie suspects handed over for trial in the Netherlands under Scottish law; UN sanctions are eased as a result.

2001 Lockerbie trial verdict: one suspect is convicted and the other is released. Sanctions are eased further.

2003 Libya announces it will end its development of weapons of mass destruction and pay compensation to victims of its 1980s terrorist campaigns; sanctions are finally lifted in 2004.

2006 US restores full diplomatic ties with Libya.

2009 Abdelbaset Ali al-Megrahi, convicted of involvement in the Lockerbie bombing, is transferred from prison in Scotland to Libya on health grounds.

2011 Street protests lead to civil war. In Benghazi and eastern Libya the opposition takes control. UN no-fly zone imposed.

«158–59 Diffusion of Knowledge

«174–75 The Ascent of Islam

«178–79 Islamic Treasures

Niger



Once the heartland of Africa's mighty medieval empires, but today one of its poorest countries.

1200s–1500s Empires of Mali and Songhay rise to power in the region.

1300s Agadez becomes an important center of trans-Saharan trade.

1883–1904 France overcomes the powerful Islamic Sokoto Empire and establishes control over the country, finally occupying Agadez after strong Tuareg resistance.

1916–17 The Tuareg occupy Agadez and control the Air Mountains.

1950s Two political movements emerge, the radical Sawaba party of Djibo Bakary and the conservative Niger Progressive Party (PPN) of Hamani Diori. Sawaba is banned in 1959.

1960 Independence from France: Diori becomes president.

1968 French open uranium mines.

1973 Sixty percent of livestock die in a severe drought.

1974 Military coup under General Seyni Kountché.

1984 Niger River dries up in a drought. Uranium boom ends.

1987 Kountché dies. General Ali Saibou eases transition to democracy.

1990–95 Tuareg rebellion.

1992 Multi-party constitution leads to democratic elections in 1993.

1996 Military coup. A new constitution in 1999 leads to multi-party elections won by Mamadou Tandja.

2004 Mamadou Tandja wins second presidential term.

2005 Ceremony at which 7,000 slaves are to be freed is canceled as the government denies the existence of slavery. Widespread protests at tax increases on basic foods.

2009 President Tandja suspends the constitution and pushes through a referendum allowing him to stand for a third term. He then wins elections which are boycotted by the opposition.

2010 President Tandja is ousted in military coup.

«360–61 The Scramble for Africa

Chad



A poor, largely desert nation ruled by ancient African kingdoms before being colonized by France.

800s Kanem–Bornu Empire is founded in the north of what is now Chad.

1500s–1600s Baguirmi and Ouaddai kingdoms hold sway over the region.

1878 Rabah Zobeir begins the conquest of Chad from Sudan.

1900 French defeat Zobeir at Kuseri.

1959 Preindependence elections result in victory for François (later Ngarta) Tombalbaye, who becomes prime minister.

1960 Independence from France.

1973 Libyans seize Aozou strip in north.

1975 Coup by General Félix Malloum.

1979–82 North-south civil war.

1982 Hissène Habré, a northerner, defeats Oueddei; he holds power to 1990.

1990 Idriss Déby seizes power and holds power in successive elections.

1994 Libya relinquishes Aozou strip.

1996 National ceasefire; new constitution.

1999–2003 Rebellion in north is ended with peace deal.

2005 Chad declares war on Sudan for trying to destabilize Chad's border region in the wake of the Darfur crisis.



Roman Libya

This magnificent Roman amphitheater stands amid the ruins of Leptis Magna, one of three Roman cities that gave their name to Tripolitania, and thus to modern Tripoli, the capital of Libya.